College Bound

ISSUES & TRENDS FOR THE COLLEGE ADMISSIONS ADVISOR

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Editor's Note: Welcome to *COLLEGE BOUNDS'S* 33rd Year! We look forward to bringing you more of the latest news from college admissions offices, national and university research results, and tips on financial aid trends and opportunities. Have a great school year!

California Bellwether for Higher Ed Trends

California is making a big impact on higher education this school year. Often seen as "the bellwether" of trends in higher education, California is addressing issues in community colleges, public universities and tuition. Here is what is happening.

California System Admits 137,000 Students. The U. of California offered nearly 137,000 students a spot on at least one of its nine undergraduate campuses. This number includes more state residents and transfer students. More than 71,000 of the freshmen are California residents, 1,114 more than last year. And more than 28,750 are transfer applicants, the highest number in university history. Of those, 24,000 were in-state transfer students.

UC Santa Barbara's Huge Pool. The U. of California Santa Barbara, for example, offered admission to 29,782 high school seniors selected from a total applicant pool of 92,017 applicants. About 32 percent of applicants were offered a place in this fall's entering class, Lisa Przekop, director of admissions, told *The Current*. It was the most selective year in its school history.

UC Santa Barbara also offered transfers spots to 10,139 students from a pool of 17,890. About 31 percent of accepted students identified themselves as members of a racial or ethnic minority group. Of admitted students, the average high school GPA was also an all-time high. The average total score on the required SATR was 1395 out of a possible 1600.

Berkeley Engineering Recruits More Women. The U. of California Berkeley's C. of Engineering posted a 28 percent increase in the number of female students admitted for the 2018-19 academic year. This year, women make up 32 percent of incoming freshmen and 26 percent of transfer students. "It's wonderful to see these numbers going up, but they're still not where we would like them to be," said Philip Kaminsky, executive associate dean.

California Pushes Community Colleges First. At the same time, California Governor Jerry Brown is pushing for a higher education model where more students save money and the state saves space in the U. of California system classrooms by starting at community college, then transferring to one of the state's four-year universities.

Meanwhile, California summer enrollment surged with Pell Grant money. Last year, Congress approved the use of Pell Grants for summer classes. As a result, enrollment at California colleges and universities grew dramatically. For example, Cal State Los Angeles doubled enrollment to about 5,900. The story was the same at Cal State campuses in Fresno, San Jose and San Diego.

Nationally, Pell Grants worth $26.6 billion were handed out to 7.1 million students during the 2016-17 school year. The average student received $3,740.

California C.C. Sign Transfer Agreement. The chancellor of California Community

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Financial Matters

FAFSA Completion Up Slightly. The number of students nationally who completed the Free Application for Federal Student Aid increased 1.9 percent in the 2018-19 cycle, according to estimates by the National College Access Network. That represents 40,602 more students who completed the application in 2017-18. The previous year, the number who completed the application increased by 9 percent, the first year to open applications in October rather than January.

Louisiana led the way in terms of percentage of high school seniors who completed the application, at 77.1 percent. Tennessee was next in the number of students who completed the application, at 76.6 percent. The District of Columbia posted a completion rate of 71.4 percent, followed by Delaware at 68.6 percent and Massachusetts at 67.2 percent.

Still, some $24 billion in financial aid is going unclaimed. A NCAN study found that school districts with higher child poverty levels have lower FAFSA completion rates. The researchers suggest that simple approaches "such as personal assistants and FAFSA completion nights" can help.

Yet, 900,000 Low-Income Students Received No Aid. Last year, more than 900,000 low-income students who were eligible for state financial aid for college never received it, as states ran out of money, according to *The Hechinger Report*. The actual number is likely much higher since many states don't keep track of the number of

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Updates on Class of 2022 Admissions

Bucknell Attracted Over 10,000 Apps. Bucknell U. in Pennsylvania welcomed 976 new students, one less than last fall's record class. Members of the Class of 2022, selected from 10,144 applicants, hail from 30 states in 46 countries. They posted high school GPA's of 3.57. Some 21 percent are students of color and 11 percent are first-generation college students.

"They founded nonprofits to raise awareness for pediatric cancer, competed in the World Championships for FIRST Robotics and performed in Off-Broadway productions," noted Kevin Mathes, dean of admissions.

Connecticut C. Sets Records. The Connecticut C. Class of 2022 was selected from a record 6,433 applicants. Half of the new class ranked in the top 10 percent of their high school class. The entire new class posted the highest standardized test scores in the college's history. Almost a quarter of the class is made up of students of color, 15 percent are first-generation students and 9 percent are international students representing 26 nations.

The Class of 2022 also includes the largest number of legacy students. The legacies "have witnessed the success that a Conn education provides over the long term," said Andrew Strickler, dean of admission and financial aid.

Dartmouth's Yield Reaches 64 Percent. Dartmouth C. received 22,033 applications for the Class of 2022 and admitted 1,925 students. It enrolled about 1,150 of them to post an all-time high yield of 64 percent. So this year, no students were taken off the wait list for the second year in a row, Lee Coffin, vice provost for enrollment, told *The Dartmouth*.

Coffin cited several reasons for this year's high yield, including new supplemental questions on the college's application that "have allowed admissions officers to determine which students fit Dartmouth well…." He also said that admissions officers have been "focused on some of the qualitative parts of who is coming to Dartmouth and to celebrate… the personal narratives of students who are enrolling." Dartmouth has also moved away from admitting transfer students.

Deep Springs Admits Women. Deep Springs C., a two-year school founded in 1917 in the high desert of California, has admitted its first class of women. Last admission cycle, Deep Springs attracted 318 applications, 135 of them from women. It admitted 10 women and five men, with full scholarships, so women make up one third of the small student body. Deep Springs students are in charge of various aspects of the college including a working ranch. And Deep Springs grads often gain entry into elite four-year colleges.

Loyola Chicago Fields Largest Class. After an exciting Final Four NCAA basketball run, Loyola U. Chicago has recruited its largest first-year class ever, enrolling 2,924 new students. Students of color make up 43 percent of the new class, while 68 percent are female students and nearly 15 percent are first-generation students. The average ACT score is 27.2, according to the *Loyola Phoenix*.

"For this upcoming cycle, we do anticipate an increase in interest given the national publicity the team and the university received," said Erin Moriarty, dean of admissions.

Mary Baldwin's Largest Class. By mid-August, Mary Baldwin U. in Virginia received deposits from 427 new students from 34 states, 83 percent of whom are women. After a few down years, the 176-year-old institution has bounced back. "We emphasized the student experience and made undergraduate admissions everyone's job," said Aimee Rose, vice president.

Tulane U. Notes John and Olivia are Most Popular Names. Only 17 percent of the 38,599 applicants were admitted to Tulane U. this year. Average SAT score was 1456. Five percent of the class is international, representing 30 different countries; 22 percent are students of color. Tulane notes that 29 students are named John, 23 Olivia. And there are six sets of twins.

Virginia Tech Revamps Application Process. Last year, Virginia Tech attracted about 32,000 applicants and admitted a little more than 60 percent. It also has added a new Early Action option. About 34 percent of Virginia Tech's first-year class of 6,400 students who enrolled are either first-generation, low-income or from an underrepresented minority.

Virginia Tech has joined 140 other colleges and universities in the Coalition for Access, Affordability and Success seeking to enroll more diverse and first-generation students who have difficulty affording college. Beginning this year, Virginia Tech will accept the Coalition's application, plus four of its own essay questions that will allow reviewers to examine the context of a student's situation. For example, did a student work a job and maintain decent grades?

Tech is looking for "students who have a positive self-concept, are working toward self-development academically and possess a commitment to improving society," said Tech president Tim Sands who said he wants 40 percent of its student body to be made up of under-represented groups by 2022. "This is not about giving anyone a break," added Luisa Havens Geraldo, vice provost for enrollment management. "In the next 20 years the institutions that figure out how to serve the people and demographics in our country are the ones that will be still standing."

Wabash Rings in A New School Year. Wabash C. president Gregory D. Hess welcomed 284 men into the Indiana school's new class during a "Ringing In" ceremony using a hand bell that once belonged to the school's first educator, Caleb Mills. The new students come from 21 states and 10 nations. Twenty-one of the freshmen were president of a class, club or organization in high school, while 14 were Eagle Scouts and three were Special Olympics coaches. "These are the men who will become some of your greatest teachers, life-long friends, business partners, the best man at your weddings and your strength in times of joy and need," Hess said. ■

CALIFORNIA

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Colleges has signed a new transfer agreement with the Association of Independent California Colleges and Universities to give community college students with an associate degree the chance to receive guaranteed acceptance to 36 private, nonprofit, four-year schools. "This is statewide with all private nonprofits, so that students have a broad range of options they can go to," said Greg Gillespie, chancellor, Ventura County C.C. District.

California Lowers Tuition. This summer, regents of the U. of California voted to cut tuition for the first time in two decades. Students will be paying $60 less this year. The action lowered the base tuition and fees to $12,570 annually.

Regents also debated, but did not act on, what the number of nonresidents the UC system would accept should be, according to *The Los Angeles Times*. In 2008, only 5.2 percent of the student body came from out-of-state or from abroad. By 2017, that percentage had grown to 17.2 percent of the system's 217,000 undergraduates.

Out-of-state and foreign students make up nearly a quarter of undergraduates at UC Berkeley, UCLA and UC San Diego, but just 2.7 percent at UC Riverside. Last year, regents voted to cap their enrollment at 18 percent at UC Davis, Santa Cruz, Santa Barbara, Riverside and Merced.

Sierra's Free First Year. Sierra C. in Northern California is offering free tuition for the first full year for qualified California students. "Studies have shown that the most successful students are those who attend full-time," said Stephanie Ortz, dean, in *The Union*. "By significantly reducing costs, we are helping them move forward with their educational plans without as much pressure to work full-time or become encumbered with financial aid debt." ■

The Counselor's Corner

A GPS for College-Bound Families

AS A COLLEGE BOUND COUNSELOR, I've now helped hundreds of students launch to college. This means I've also walked with hundreds of parents as they learned to let go and allowed their children to steer their own ships. I know how disorienting this can feel firsthand: I've seen my own two children off to college as well.

So here is the advice I give to parents to help reassure them and to guide their way. With a little direction, parents and students can not only survive, but thrive, on this road. I call this my GPS (Guidelines for Parental Support) to help families find their way in the college search, application and selection process:

Mary Ann Willis

1. Hold Steady. This process takes work—every day. Self-awareness and exploration are vital. Students should grow tremendously through the process.

2. Be Patient. Remember that this is a gradual process. A student begins the journey to college as a high school freshman. From then on, his or her job is to grow and be the best he or she can be—not to pad a resume.

3. Navigate, Don't Drive. A parent's role is maintenance and support. But a student must own the process. DO NOT do things for a teenager that he or she could do independently. By stepping back, parents boost students' confidence and foster the development of responsibility and personal engagement.

4. Stay Connected. Work closely with the school counselor or the school staff member who works with students in the college application and selection process.

5. Get Informed. Parents need to maximize opportunities and resources. They should go to college fairs. Read information provided by the student's school. Attend evening programs. Provide a student, if at all possible, with opportunities to visit campuses (but have the student schedule all the events for the visit.) Know that expressing interest can be a factor in admissions. And don't take everything you read in the media or see on television as gospel.

6. Budget (part one). Families need to discuss financial parameters. In the long run, there are only two things more expensive than going to college: not going, or going and not earning a degree. Apply for aid (https://fafsa.ed.gov/)—you miss 100 percent of the shots you don't take.

7. Budget (part two). In any year a student is attending college, parents will need to fill out the FAFSA and, for some schools, also the CSS PROFILE and/or institutional financial analysis of the family situation—yes, even if it has been done before. Colleges and the federal government expect families to pay for college to the degree that the family is deemed able to do so.

8. Be Scholarship-Savvy. Merit scholarships are worth the effort to pursue. But never pay for a scholarship or a scholarship search. (Learn more at https://studentaid.ed.gov/sa/types/scams.) The competition for legitimate scholarships is more intense than most people realize. Some schools require financial aid applications even for merit funds. Some colleges use published formulas: a certain GPA/test score will yield a specific amount. There are conditions for maintaining scholarships. Keep in mind: Most highly-selective schools do not offer merit scholarships.

9. Test Up. Admissions testing is likely more important than the student (or family) wants it to be and less important than they think it is. Visit www.fairtest.org and see how many schools have gone test-optional. Colleges are crafting a class, and the process is more about the college's institutional needs and interests than most families realize. Application files are read in a matter of minutes. Meeting all deadlines—the school's deadline, application and scholarship deadlines and financial aid deadlines—is imperative.

10. Keep it Real. Highly-selective colleges have far more applicants than spaces. The national college admissions rate is now upwards of 60 percent. Concentrate on helping a student find fertile grounds for his or her talents, in and out of the classroom. The list should be vertical: 4-6 schools for most students, 6-8 options if some choices are highly selective. Don't apply at random. Remember that successful people come from everywhere. ■

Mary Ann Willis is director of college counseling at Bayside Academy in Daphne, Alabama, and CB *advisor.*

COUNSELOR'S BOOKSHELF

The Best 384 Colleges: 2019 Edition, The Princeton Review surveyed 138,000 students at 384 top colleges to rate their schools on dozens of 62 topics.

For example, Bentley U.'s career center ranked first; Vanderbilt U. ranked first on "great financial aid;" the U.S. Military Academy had the "most accessible professors;" Washington U. in St. Louis had the "best college dorms;" Bucknell U. had the "most beautiful campus;" the U. of Alabama at Tuscaloosa had the "best athletic facilities;" the "happiest students" were found at the C. of William & Mary; and American U. had the "most politically active students." ISBN-10: 1524758191; $23.71. See, www.PrincetonReview.com/best384.

2019 Fiske Guide To Colleges by Edward B. Fiske includes top 10 "best buy" private universities: Birmingham-Southern C.; Grinnell C.; Houghton C.; Kalamazoo C.; Mount Holyoke C.; Oglethorpe U.; Olin College of Engineering; Rice U.; Vanderbilt U. and Warren Wilson College.

"Best buy" public universities include: U. of Arizona; The Evergreen State C.; U. of Florida; U. of Iowa; New C. of Florida; U. of North Carolina at Chapel Hill; Purdue U.; SUNY-Binghamton; Texas A&M U. and Truman State University. ISBN-10: 1492662097; $24.99. ■

Other State News

Georgia Transforms Traditional Classrooms. The 5,750 members of the U. of Georgia's Class of 2022 arrived with average ACT scores of 30 and will benefit from several new academic initiatives. One is an "active learning initiative," that is promoting "higher levels of student engagement and success by transforming traditional classrooms into environments that foster critical thinking, discussion and teamwork." They will also be able to choose from two new "Living Learning Communities," one on entrepreneurship and the other on research.

"We hope to provide these students with a transformational experience that allows exploration and hands-on engagement," said Rahul Shrivastav, vice president for instruction.

Hawaii Promise. Governor David Ige signed legislation expanding the Hawaii Promise scholarship program. The legislation also appropriated $700,000 to help qualified students who are enrolled in any community college campus in the U. of Hawaii system to cover unmet education costs such as tuition, books, supplies, fees and local transportation. According to the U. of Hawaii, 1,500 students benefited from Hawaii Promise scholarships last fall, with an average grant of $1,200. It's estimated that new funding will support an additional 500 to 600 students during the 2018-19 school year.

Illinois Pledges Four-Year Support. A new Illinois law guarantees that students who receive grants through the Monetary Award Program (MAP) during their first year of college will have priority access for grant renewals. About 130,000 students across Illinois received MAP grants in fiscal 2018.

"This is a huge step in the right direction," said Barbara Wilson, executive vice president for academic affairs for the U. of Illinois system. "It gives students some continuity and commitment for four years."

Maryland's SmartSave. At the direction of Governor Larry Hogan, Maryland has created a new website to help residents more easily find information about college financing and student debt. The site features material on grants, scholarships, tuition waivers and more. See, www.MHEC.Maryland.gov.

Minnesota Offers Financial Counseling. The U. of Minnesota has cut the number of students leaving the university with debt from 43 percent to 35 percent between 2009 and 2017. One reason is the new One Stop, a financial wellness resource center, where students are counseled on debt management and budgeting during one-on-one appointments. Betsy Everts, One Stop assistant director, said she hopes the university will help students manage finances early in their college career by adding a more comprehensive one-credit course for students to improve their financial literacy.

No Tuition for Some New Jersey Residents. For the past two years, Rutgers U.-Camden has eliminated tuition for New Jersey students from families earning $60,000 or less. Students from families earning $60,000-$80,000 pay only 25 percent of standard tuition. And those from families earning between $80,000 and $100,000 pay only half-tuition. Perhaps as a result, the number of African American students staying in-state has grown by 114 percent. The number of Hispanic students staying in-state to go to school has increased by 70 percent.

N.Y. Students Rejected From Free College Program. Over 20,000 students received Excelsior Scholarships or about 3.2 percent of New York's 633,543 undergraduates, according to an analysis by the Center for an Urban Future, a New York City think tank. Of the 63,599 students who applied, 43,513 or 68 percent were denied the scholarship. Many were turned away because they didn't meet all the requirements, such as taking 30 credits per year. A spokesman for New York Governor Andrew Cuomo said that 53 percent of New York state public college students receive some form of state aid.

Wisconsin Supports STEM Transfers. The Wisconsin Institute for Science Education and Community Engagement at the U. of Wisconsin-Madison is using a $1 million donation from the Howard Hughes Medical Institute to build a system that supports transfer students who are studying science, biology, engineering or math (STEM).

The insitute is working primarily with Madison C. and the UW System's two-year institutions. It hopes to admit 375 transfer students over the next five years who already have some background in STEM fields. ■

NEWS YOU CAN USE

Spring Enrollment Dipped Slightly. "In spring 2018, overall postsecondary enrollments decreased 1.3 percent from the previous spring," according to the National Student Clearinghouse Research Center. Enrollment was down 6.8 percent at four-year for-profit institutions, down 2 percent at two-year public institutions, down .4 percent at four-year private nonprofit institutions and down .2 percent at four-year public institutions.

Test Optional. More colleges became test optional recently. Among schools declaring that their students no longer are required to take standardized tests are Duke U.; Brown U.; Princeton U.; Stanford U. and Ball State U. in Indiana. However, Stanford still "strongly recommends" that students take the tests. ■

Financial Matters

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eligible students that they turned away. In 10 states, more than half of eligible students didn't receive a grant, including Oregon, Kansas, Delaware and Illinois.

Maryland turned away 18,000 eligible low-income students, Kentucky ran out of funds for 28,000 students and in Florida, more than 100,000 went without aid.

"In most states, aid programs come from the general fund, and once it's gone, it's gone," said Sarah Pingel, senior policy analyst at the Education Commission of the States.

"People may think this is just happening in their state," said Kerry Warick, director of policy and advocacy for the National College Access Network. "But when you look around, you can see this is a national problem."

Dramatic Disparities In Default Rates. The current default rate on student loans for all college entrants is 17 percent. According to a new report in the Brookings Institution's Evidence Speaks series, students enrolling in for-profit colleges are 14 percent more likely to default than other students, after controlling for whether or not students graduated and their post-college employment status and income.

Brookings Senior Fellow Judith Scott-Clayton also found that while the default rate among black graduates is more than five times the rate of white graduates, there are no racial differences in the rate at which students who have defaulted are able to resolve their defaults.

Congress Restored Perkins Grants. This summer, Congress reauthorized the Carl D. Perkins Career and Technical Education Act, which gives states more than $1 billion in career and technical education grants each year. ■

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